(11) Some three months into the trial before the special tribunal, and with matters going from bad to worse, on 11 August 1930, Bhagat Singh petitioned the high court in Lahore. He explained that he and the co-accused were now refusing to attend court ‘in protest’ given ‘the treatment meted out to the accused’. In fact, ‘the petitioner went on hunger strike on July 28th, 1930 in protest against certain regulations of the jail department’. But ‘the trial is entering a new stage, i.e. the Prosecution evidence is about to be closed and the Petitioner is to be called upon to make his statement and to offer any defence . . .’. However, ‘the jail authorities have altogether stopped all the interviews with his relatives and legal advisers’. But ‘this purely executive affair is hampering the cause of justice and these Orders of the executive are highly illegal’. The fact is that ‘the Petitioner wants the help of his relatives and legal advisers in deciding the most delicate question of his defence’. After that, Bhagat Singh’s flair for the legal niceties of trial advocacy becomes thunderously clear. He argues that ‘that there is a special provision in the Lahore Conspiracy Case Ordinance to the effect that if any accused voluntarily disables himself by hunger striking, or otherwise, or resists his production before the court, he shall still have the right to be represented by Counsel in his absence’. Thus, unless the jail authorities grant him access to his relatives and legal advisers, ‘the accused feels quite handicapped’. Therefore, ‘in the interests of justice and fair play, the court be pleased to intervene in this affair and to issue such instructions to the authorities concerned, as would be necessary to give full and proper facilities for arranging defence adequately in a case where the petitioner is being tried for such serious offences as may bring the extreme penalty of law’. Bhagat Singh pleaded that the high court therefore ‘issue urgent orders for allowing interviews etc. . . .’. It was to be all in vain. The next day the jail authorities stopped all interviews and declared that the high court had no jurisdiction to get involved in the matter (Lahore Archives, previously unpublished).